

Gender as a product of politics: Evidence of a reciprocal relationship between political and gender identities

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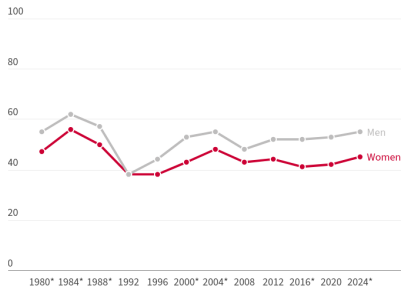
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Sex gaps with gendered explanations

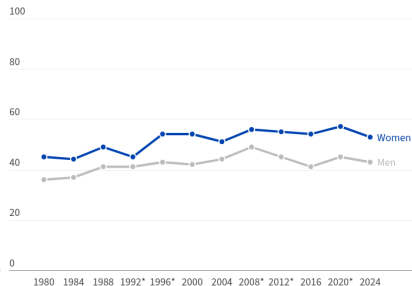
Vote for Major-Party Presidential Nominees by Gender

(1980-2024)

Vote for Republican Nominees



Vote for Democratic Nominees



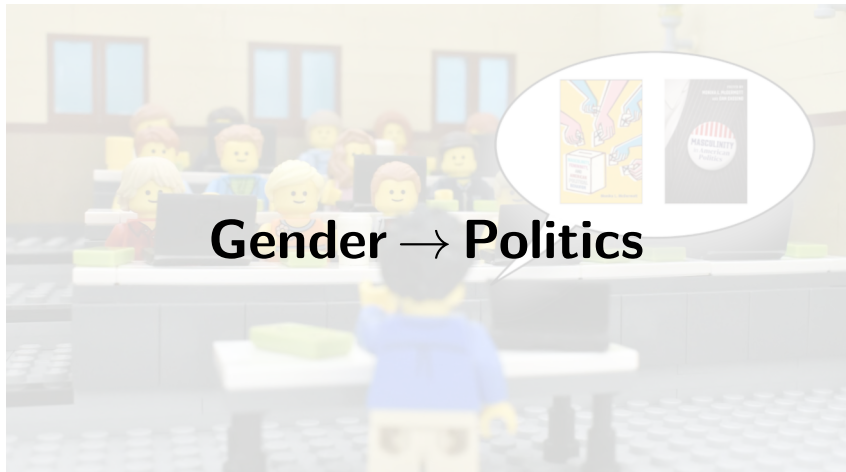
* Presidential nominee of this party was successful in this election. The gender gap in vote choice is calculated based on the gender difference in voter support for the winning candidate.

Sources: Edison Exit Poll (formerly Voter News Service 1992-2000) and CBS/NY Times (1980-1988).

Sex gaps with gendered explanations



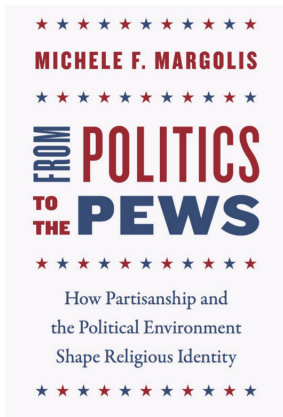
Sex gaps with gendered explanations



Gender → Politics

A second, non-mutually exclusive possibility

- ▶ We will not argue against the influence of gender on politics
- ▶ However, existing work also suggests that individual's politics may influence their ostensibly fixed demographic traits (e.g., Egan, 2020; Margolis, 2018)



Identity as Dependent Variable: How Americans Shift Their Identities to Align with Their Politics

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Abstract: Political science generally treats identities such as ethnicity, religion, and sexuality as “unmoved markers” in the chain of causality. I hypothesize that the growing salience of partisanship and ideology as social identities in the United States, combined with the increasing demographic distinctiveness of the nation’s two political coalitions, is leading some Americans to engage in a self-categorization and deprofessionalization process in which they shift their identities toward the demographic prototypes of their political groups. Analysis of a representative panel data set that tracks identities and political affiliations over a 4-year span confirms that small but significant shares of Americans engage in identity switching regarding ethnicity, religion, sexual orientation, and class that is predicted by partisanship and ideology in their past, bringing their identities into alignment with their politics. These findings enrich and complicate our understanding of the relationship between identity and politics and suggest caution in treating identities as unchanging phenomena.

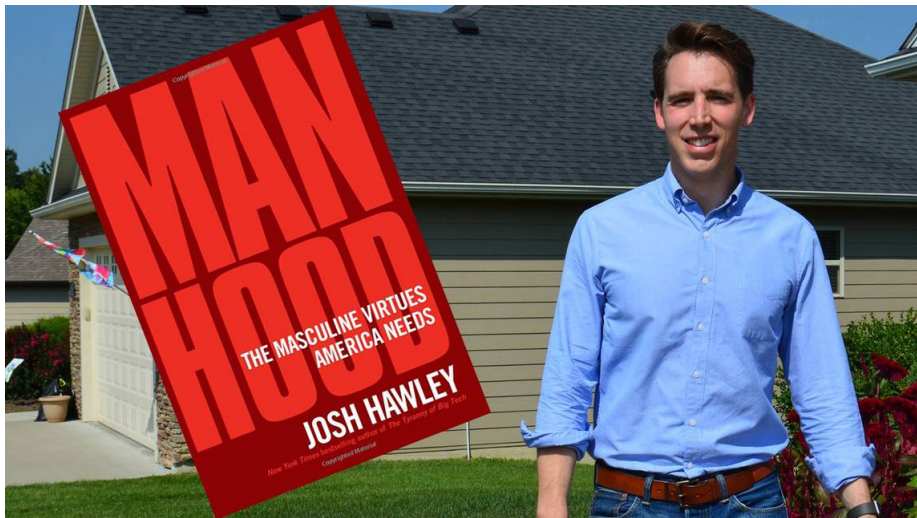
Verification Materials: The data and materials required to verify the computational reproducibility of the results, procedures, and analyses in this article are available on the American Journal of Political Science Datastore within the Harvard DataScience Network, at <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/V928W8>.

In recent years, identity has emerged as a key explanatory variable in both academic and popular accounts of U.S. politics. The shift was reinforced by the 2016 presidential election, which revealed an American electorate deeply divided along the lines of identity dimensions like race, Latino origin, religion, and sexual orientation. Many political scientists now point to group identity as a key independent variable predicting political behavior (e.g., Abdelal et al. 2006; Achen and Baricak 2016; Huddy 2003; Kinder and Kalmoe 2017), returning full circle to the focus placed on identity by some of the earliest academic accounts of voting and attitudes (Berelson, Lazarsfeld, and McPhee 1954; Campbell et al. 1960).

In political science, it is often implicitly assumed that identities are stable and therefore can be confidently considered to be antecedent to political attitudes and behavior. But recent empirical work has challenged the premise that identities are exogenous to politics. These findings have been most pronounced in the religion and politics literature, where analyses of U.S. panel data demonstrate short-term change in Americans’ religious

identification and participation in response to their partisanship and ideology (Campbell et al. 2018; Djaque, Nebeid, and Sokhey 2018; Hout and Fricker 2014; Margolis 2018a, 2018b; Partskies 2008; Putnam and Campbell 2010). Other research has found that politically salient factors in Americans’ backgrounds and upbringing are long-term predictors of their present identities with regard to race (Davenport 2016) and sexual orientation (Egan 2012), indicating that those identities too can be endogenous to politics.

Previous work has looked at identities one category at a time, and thus the mechanisms of politicized identity change provided by researchers have largely been grounded in aspects of particular identity categories being studied. Here, I use social identity theory, offered by a few scholars to explain the effect of politics on religion (Campbell et al. 2018; Partskies 2008), to hypothesize more broadly about how politics can lead Americans to shift their identities across multiple categories that we typically think of as fixed. I begin with the well-documented fact that for more and more Americans, politics has





We reconsider the influence of gender (masculinity and femininity) on politics via a two study design

1. Seven years of panel data drawn from USC's Understanding America Survey
 - ▶ Drawn from a probability frame
2. Novel survey experiment

Observable implications

H1. Individuals with more (less) traditional gender self-conceptions should become more likely to identify as conservative and Republican (liberal and Democratic) over time

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H3. Political priming will shifts respondents' masculine and feminine self-evaluations

Analysis I: Understanding America Survey

- ▶ We draw on data from six waves ($N > 10,000$)

Period	Survey date	Topic
$t = 1$	October 2018	Gender
$t = 2$	August 2019	Politics
$t = 3$	January 2021	Gender
$t = 4$	December 2023	Politics
$t = 5$	January 2025	Gender
$t = 6$	December 2025	Politics

Variable codings

- ▶ 100 point ideology (liberal → conservative)
- ▶ 5 point PID (Democratic → Republican)
- ▶ 100 point gender self-conception (incongruent → congruent)¹

gen_5 (own perception of your masculinity, femininity in section Perceptions)

Thinking of how **you personally** would define the terms "masculine" and "feminine", please move the slider on the bar below to represent how masculine or feminine you consider yourself to be.

Click or tap on the bar, then move the slider to where it should be
RANGE 0..100

¹One wave is recoded and one wave is partially recoded. We create congruency by reverse coding women.

Analysis I: Understanding America Survey

- ▶ Data is modeling using a continuous time cross-lagged panel model (CT CLPM) via the `ctsem` package (Driver, Oud, & Voelkle, 2017)

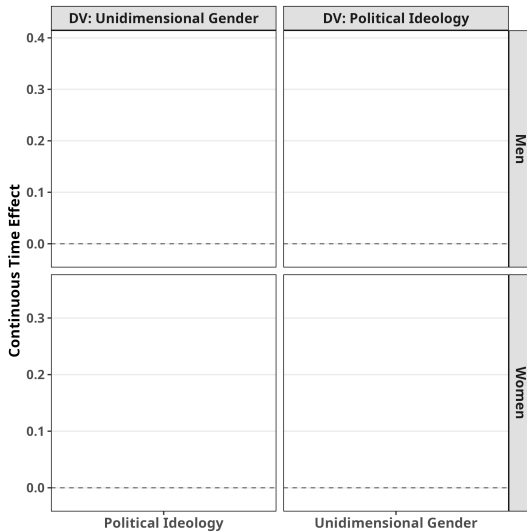
Analysis I: Understanding America Survey



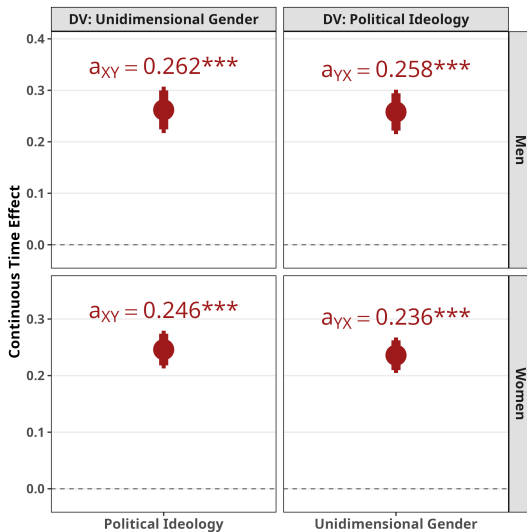
- ▶ Data is modeling using a continuous time cross-lagged panel model (CT CLPM) via the `ctsem` package (Driver, Oud, & Voelkle, 2017)
- ▶ The CT CLPM models gender (X) and political affiliation (Y) as dynamic processes evolving over time, and summarizes these movements in a single drift matrix $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times 2}$
 - ▶ The two cross effect entries in this matrix (a_{XY} and a_{YX}) are our quantities of interest.²

²Cross-effects are only interpretable under a timeframe Δt with the transformation $\exp(\mathbf{A} \cdot \Delta t)$.

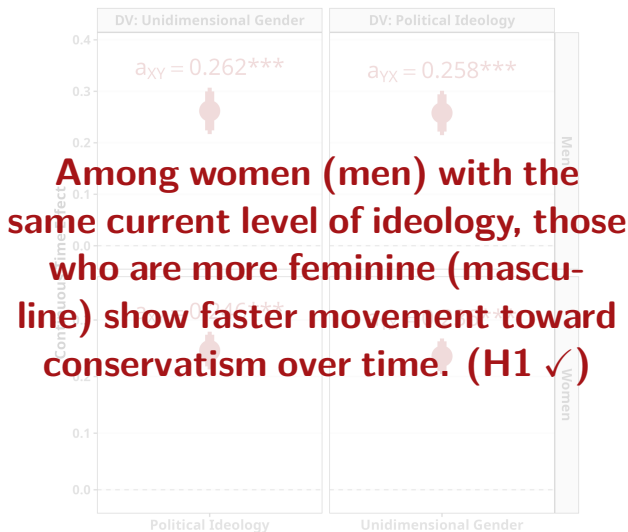
Analysis I: Results



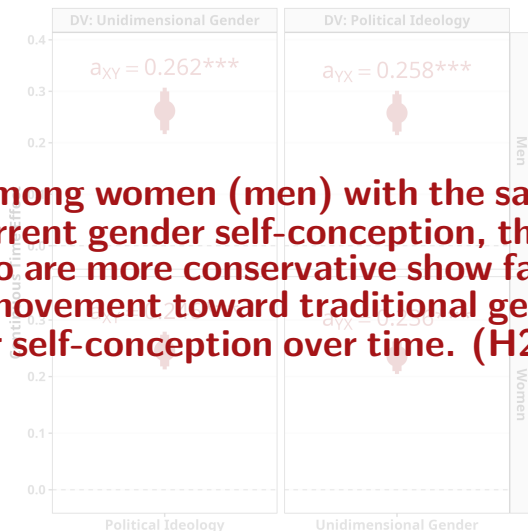
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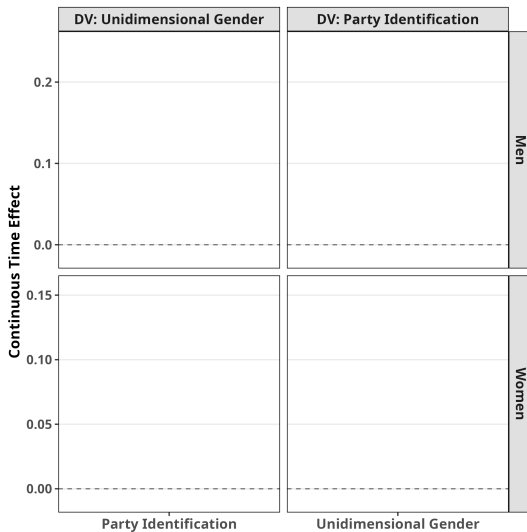


Analysis I: Results

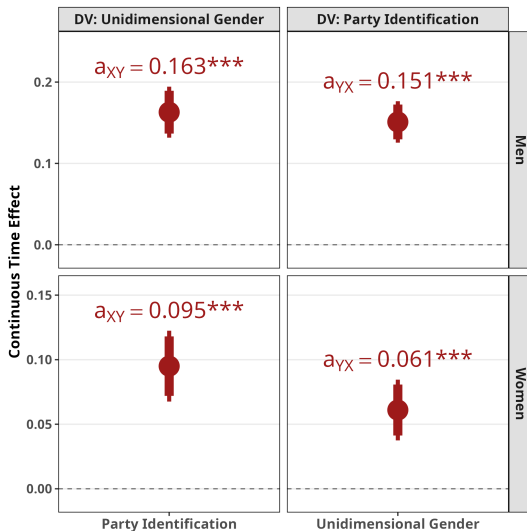


Among women (men) with the same current gender self-conception, those who are more conservative show faster movement toward traditional gender self-conception over time. (H2 ✓)

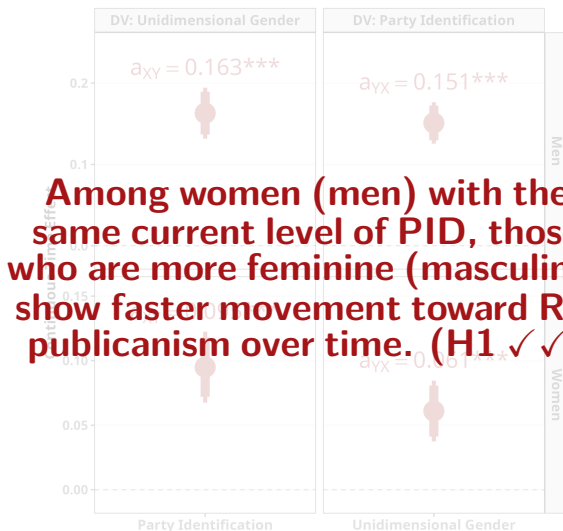
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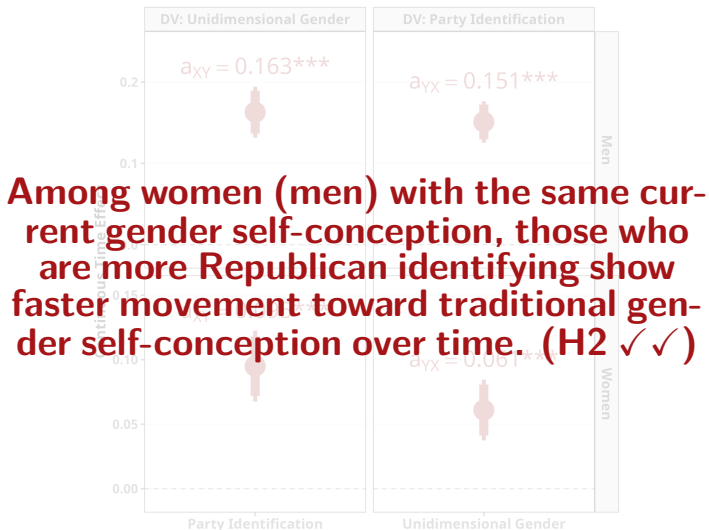
Analysis I: Results



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Analysis II: Experimental evidence

- ▶ Panel models strengthen causal inference relative to cross-sectional designs (Vaisey & Miles, 2019)
- ▶ To secure the strongest available causal leverage, we pair this with a pre-registered survey experiment (Humphreys et al., 2013; Migeul et al., 2014; Monogan III, 2013; Mullinix et al., 2015)

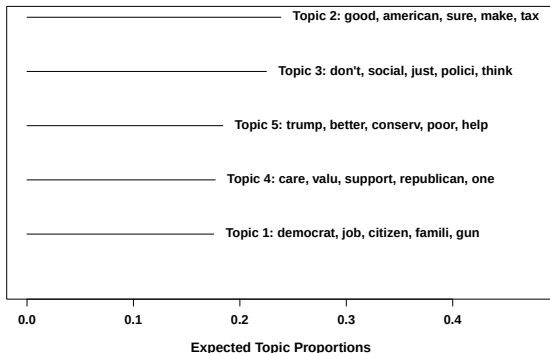
Analysis II: Experimental evidence

- ▶ Respondents are randomly assigned to a control or treatment condition.
- ▶ In both conditions, respondents fill out their masculine and feminine self-evaluations (LO $\rightarrow$ HI)
- ▶ In the treatment condition, before doing so, respondents complete an open-ended question where they list “three or four things they especially like about their party” (Klar, 2014)
- ▶ We report the treatment coefficient from the specification listed in our PAP (listed on OSF)

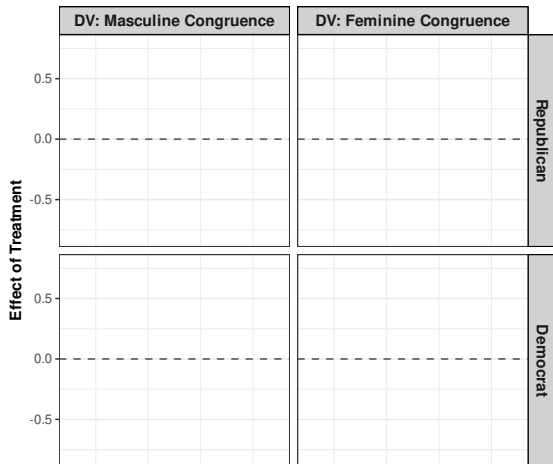
Analysis II: Experimental evidence

- Approximately 90% of respondents write something in the text box. An STM of responses ($K = 5$) confirms that responses were on-topic

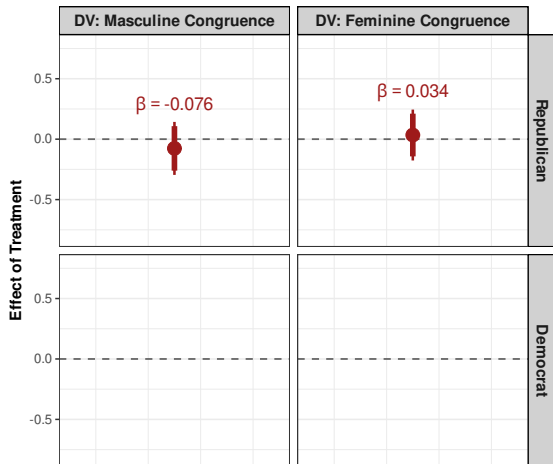
(Lucas et al., 2015; Roberts et al., 2014)



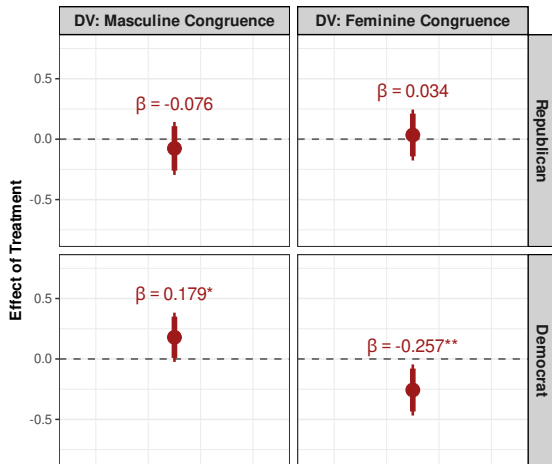
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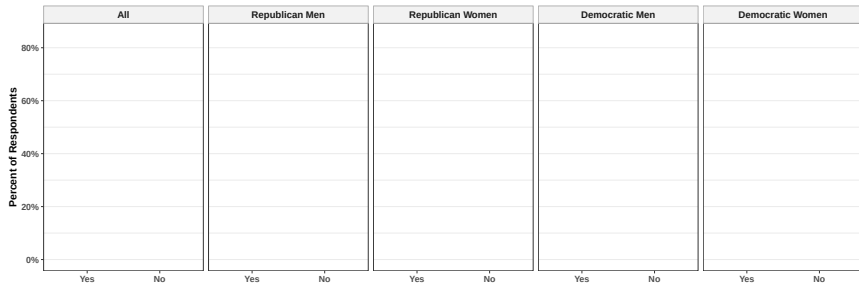
Analysis II: Results



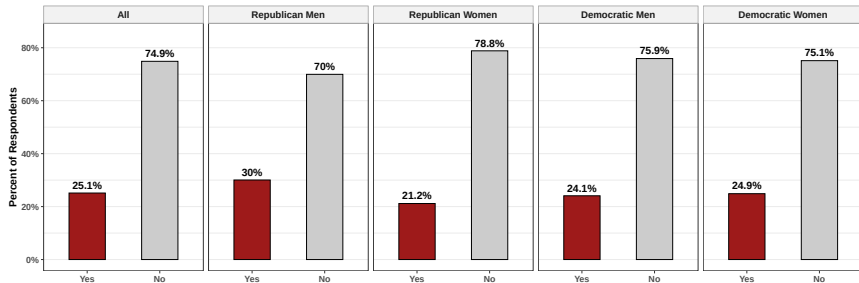
Analysis II: Perceptions of political influence

- ▶ The UAS panel data and experimental results both suggest that an individual's politics indeed influence their gender identity
- ▶ However, causal identification in the CLPM is limited and the causal effects of the experimental results limited to Democrats
- ▶ To further probe whether politics has influenced their gender identity, we simply ask respondents (cf. Cramer, 2016; Schildraut, 2013; Williamson, 2017)

Analysis II: Perceptions of political influence



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Main takeaways

1. We reinforce the causal influence of gender on political identity
2. We also advance evidence for a second complementary causal influence of political identity on gender identity

Thank you!



Thank you!



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